

SEARCHING THE INTERNET

The Internet is a global network of computer networks. It holds massive amounts of information and is constantly growing and changing. To find the information you require on the Internet you must use a search strategy. The Information Process is an effective strategy for any research, and can be very successfully applied to Internet based research.

Remember to ALWAYS USE A SEARCH ENGINE, unless you are certain of an exact address.

Applying the Information Process to Internet Research

1. **DEFINE keywords.** Use reference sources such as encyclopedias, (including online encyclopedias such as World Book Online), to get an overview of your area of research. Identify as many keywords as possible that describe the topic.
2. **LOCATE.** Select the search engine that will be most useful for this research. (e.g. [Weblinks Online](#) which is designed for Australian school students can be a useful starting point for many topics.)
Enter keywords in a search engine. Use nouns, (verbs, adjectives, etc are often ignored by search engines). The more appropriate your keywords the better.
Put the most relevant words first; search engines tend to rank results in order according to the first words or phrases used in the search.
3. **SELECT** the most relevant information. Identify and visit what appear to be the best web sites for your needs from the list of hits in the search engine. Assess the visited sites for relevance and accuracy. Note or copy relevant information. Record the addresses and times useful sites are visited for later inclusion in the bibliography.
4. **ORGANISE** the selected information. If you haven't located sufficient information try a different search engine. (All search engines function differently, and no one engine can cover more than a small proportion of the Web. To find out more about the different functions of various search engines visit [Noodletools](#).)
5. **PRESENT** the information in the most appropriate form.

EVALUATE each step in the process for this research. Would it have been more efficient to spend more time defining the topic and identifying keywords? Might other search engines have been more effective in locating information? Did you remember to record web site addresses as you used them for later inclusion in the bibliography? (See the SMC Bibliography Guide)